The Ball Poem

The big idea

In **The Ball Poem**, **John Berryman** describes a boy who loses his ball in the harbour. Through this small loss the poet explores a big idea: learning to cope with **loss** is a part of **growing up**.

What happens

- A boy's **ball** bounces down the street and **into the water** of a harbour. He stands rigid, staring down into the harbour in **shaking grief**.
- The poet says it is **no use** giving him **another ball** or saying "there are other balls" — the boy is grieving for **this** ball, linked to his happy childhood days.
- The poet does not intrude; he wants the boy to learn on his own.
- The boy is learning the **"epistemology of loss"** — the knowledge (nature) of loss — how to stand up and bear it.
- **"Money is external"**: money can buy another ball, but it cannot buy back memories or the feelings attached to things lost.
- Every man must eventually lose things; the boy is learning what every person must learn — to **accept loss and move on**.

BALL = CHILDHOOD

The ball symbolises the boy's **childhood, innocence and memories**. Losing it is his first lesson in the permanence of loss.

Poetic devices

- **Free verse** — no regular rhyme scheme or metre (some irregular rhymes like ball/all).
- **Symbolism:** the ball (childhood, possessions, memories).
- **Imagery:** the ball bouncing merrily down the street and into the water.
- **Repetition:** "merrily bouncing, down the street, and then merrily over".
- **Rhetorical question:** "What is the boy now, who has lost his ball, what, what is he to do?"
- **Enjambment** throughout.

THE POET DOES NOT CONSOLE THE BOY

The poet deliberately **does not** offer him another ball; he believes the boy must learn responsibility and acceptance by himself.

Message and value points

- Loss is inevitable; maturity means accepting it.
- Material things can be replaced, but emotional value cannot be bought.
- Growing up involves learning responsibility for what we possess.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why does the poet not want to give the boy another ball? What is meant by "epistemology of loss"? "Money is external" — explain. What does the ball symbolise? What is the boy learning?

Quick recap

- John Berryman; free verse.
- Ball lost in the harbour; another ball is "worthless".
- Epistemology of loss; money is external.
- Theme: loss and growing up.

Practice questions

1. Where does the boy's ball go?

   (a) Into a garden (b) Under a car (c) Into the water of the harbour (d) Onto a roof

2. Why does the poet not want to offer the boy another ball?

   (a) He is poor (b) The boy must learn to bear loss himself (c) Balls are expensive (d) The boy does not like balls

3. "Epistemology of loss" means

   (a) the price of lost things (b) the fear of losing (c) understanding the nature of loss (d) the ways to find lost things

4. "Money is external" suggests that

   (a) money cannot buy back memories and emotions (b) money is kept outside the house (c) money is useless (d) money buys happiness

5. The poem is written in

   (a) ababcc rhyme (b) sonnet form (c) free verse (d) couplets only

6. The ball symbolises the boy's

   (a) hobby (b) friend (c) school (d) childhood and innocence

7. What lesson does the boy learn from losing the ball? Why does the poet not help him?

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. c 4. a 5. c 6. d 7. see notes